

Cover story PROFILE



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Bollywood's new MAHATMA

RAJKUMAR HIRANI

He's Dr Feel Good on a silver streak. Not content with creating Munnabhai and Circuit, the FTII-trained editor has given the country three more memorable idiots.

By Kaveree Bamzai

Rajkumar Hirani is not perfect. Thankfully. He can get agitated, as we saw when asked about the story credit for *3 Idiots*. He can never be satisfied, as was clear when he sent a note to co-writer of *Lage Raho Munnabhai* and *3 Idiots*, Abhijat Joshi, asking him to keep the scenes shorter for the next script. And yes, he does like to play the fool, as he did with actor Omi Vaidya, who was the unforgettable Chatur Ramalingam, beguiling him into thinking he would have to wear a golden thong, not a stars and stripes undie, in the now controversial *3 Idiots* ragging scene. Yes, he's not perfect. But as the creator of three of Bollywood's recent most memorable mavericks, Munnabhai, Circuit and Rancho, he's close. The collective box office revenue from his three movies, all produced by FTII senior Vidhu Vinod Chopra, is over Rs 450 crore. His contribution to street language can easily fill a pocket dictionary. What's more, trawl through his wide expanse of friends in Bollywood, mostly from his days at the FTII from where he graduated in 1987, and you'll find only superlatives, no sting.

And why not? It's not every day that one of the brotherhood achieves such success. Much of it is because the 44-year-old is never happy with his work. He's not in love with his words or his pictures. Says FTII batchmate and cinematographer on *Lage Raho Munnabhai* and *3 Idiots*, C.K. Muraleedharan, "Till we finish a scene, he will be improving it, every word, every line." His training as an editor means he doesn't overshoot and can make seamless transitions. So familiar is he with the work as director, that he can actually remake